



Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series 1: Emergence of Buddhism and the Core Teachings

Phnom Penh, November 8, 2023 - The Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series 1, hosted by CamTech University in collaboration with Kol Tor Teung Pagoda, brought together a distinguished panel of experts from various fields to critically discuss the significance of Buddhism's core teachings in the modern era, particularly in the context of emerging technologies like Artificial Intelligence (AI). The seminar, attended by 150 participants from CamTech University, including leadership team members, faculty members, staff, and students, aimed to explore the intersection of Buddhism and technology.

The seminar was led by Venerable Dr. Kou Sopheap, a renowned Cambodian Buddhist Monk Scholar, who delivered a comprehensive lecture on Buddhism's core teachings, including "to abstain from all evils, to cultivate good, and to purify one's mind." These principles form a graded sequence of steps progressing from the outward and preparatory to the inward and essential. The culmination of these principles is the purification of the mind. To achieve this, he emphasized the importance of cultivating compassion (Mettā Bhāvanā - មេត្តាកាវន្តា), wisdom (Paññā Bhāvanā - បញ្ញាកាវន្តា), and mindfulness (Cittā Bhāvanā - ចិត្តាកាវន្តា) in all aspects of life and the need for purification of the mind to achieve inner peace and wisdom.

The seminar examined the relevance of Buddhism's core teachings in today's world, particularly in the context of emerging technologies like AI. The panel discussion covered four key areas:

- Meditation's potential to purify the mind and cultivate wisdom, with a focus on its applications in AI research and development.
- The benefits of integrating Buddhist values into AI systems, such as promoting empathy and compassion, and the ethical considerations that arise from this approach.
- Interdisciplinary collaboration between technologists, ethicists, and philosophers is crucial to ensure responsible and socially conscious AI development.
- The challenges posed by AI and technology, including data privacy, algorithmic bias, social justice, and other ethical concerns.

The seminar also explored the concept of “defilements”, or “roots of evil” as described by the Buddha, including greed, hatred, and delusion. These defilements can manifest in modern society through online harassment, social media addiction, consumerism, and other negative behaviors that lead to suffering and harm.

The seminar concluded with a call to action for all participants, including lecturers, students, future engineers, architects, and policymakers to integrate Buddhist values into their daily lives and work towards creating a more compassionate and wise society. The event was made possible through the collaborative efforts of CamTech University and Kol Tor Teung Pagoda.

The Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series is an ongoing initiative that explores the intersection of Buddhism and technology. Future seminars will convene experts from diverse fields to examine AI's ethical implications and integrate Buddhist values into its development. By adopting a comprehensive approach, the series balances information with inclusivity and engagement, fostering a sense of community among participants while providing a platform for knowledge sharing.

